The Women of Lockerbie

By Deborah Brevoort

INTRODUCTION

On Wed. Dec. 21, 1988, Pan Am Flight 103 exploded in midair as it traveled from London to New York City. Before it could reach the Atlantic, a timer-activated bomb detonated inside the plane from its hiding spot in a cassette player packed away in a suitcase. The explosion scattered pieces of the plane and the remains of the 243 passengers and 16 crew members over 850 square miles of Lockerbie, Scotland.

Now, seven years later, the women of Lockerbie want to save the articles of clothing that were scattered from the crash, wash them, and return them to the victims' families. Their act of compassion is challenged by George Jones, a representative from the U.S Government sent to take care of the situation. He has directions to have all of the clothing, stored in a warehouse as evidence, burned due to contamination. The Women of Lockerbie by Deborah Brevoort

GEORGE: These women are driving me crazy!

Look.

Let me give you a piece of advice about the women of Lockerbie.

Don't be fooled by the lace on their collars.

Or the flowers on their teacups.

They're not the sweet little old ladies they appear to be.

They're tigers.

And they're ferocious.

You know what they just did?

They called in the television crews!

The *networks*.

The *American* networks.

They're all down at the warehouse

With their reporters

Waiting for a statement from me!

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And that's not all.

There are two hundred women with them!

Two hundred women!

With *candles*.

They're trying to create an international incident, these people

BILL: But I thought Lockerbie was already an international incident.

GEORGE: Lockerbie? Hardly!

The world has forgotten all about Lockerbie

They forgot about it two weeks after the crash.

But if those women get it back in the news . . . !

Well, then it will be. And then I'll *never* get out of here!

BILL: You don't like it here?

GEORGE: What's to like?

Lockerbie is the Siberia of the State Department!

But.

You have to do your time in places like this

Before you get the better assignments.

Me, I'd rather be someplace else.

You know, places like . . .

Kuwait . . .

Tel Aviv . . .

The hot spots.

And if I handle this right, I just might get there.

BILL: Then why are you doing it, if I might ask?

GEORGE: You mean this business with the clothes?

BILL: Yes.

GEORGE: I have orders from Washington.

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They want things wrapped up here.

Quickly.

So that's what I'm doing.

Look. This whole affair has gone on long enough.

These people should just get over it.

It's been seven years.

I mean . . . move on, for God's sake.

Get a life!

I've tried telling them that,

But of course, they won't listen.

They sent the mayor to see me.

They sent the *bishop*, for God's sake.

Next, they'll probably send in a *mother*!

The mothers are the worst.

They come in clutching the baby pictures.

Johnny blowing out the candles on his birthday cake.

Little Timmy smiling with his mouth full of braces.

The mothers will drive you crazy.

There is always a mother who makes it impossible to do your job.

BILL: What about the fathers?

GEORGE: Oh, I have to deal with them too.

But men . . .

Men are different.

Thank God.

You can always reason with a man.

At least they don't shove those pictures in my face.

(Bill pulls out his wallet and opens it)

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What do you have there?

BILL: My son's school picture from the sixth grade.

Smiling. With his mouth full of braces.

Look.

(Bill shoves the picture in George's face).

GEORGE: *(Pause)*

Was your son . . . uh . . . on board?

BILL: Yes

GEORGE: Oh. *(Pause)* I didn't know . . .

BILL: His body was never found.

He's still out here somewhere.

GEORGE: *(Pause)* I'm . . . sorry.

(Pause) Um. What was his name?

BILL: Adam. Adam Alexander Livingston.

GEORGE: Oh, yes. Yes. I, h, seem to recall it . . . .

BILL: And here is a picture when he hit a home run.

In the Little League.

The game was tied and the bases were loaded.

GEORGE: Yeah?

BILL: Yeah! He brought them all home.

And here . . .

Here is the ticket stub

From the Yankee game I took him to on his last birthday.

I just found this a few minutes ago, in the pocket of my coat.

Funny.

I haven't worn this coat in years.

(Pause)

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Mr. Jones.

Do you have children?

GEORGE: No. No, I don't

Don't have a wife.

Well, I had one.

Had two, actually.

But we never got around to having kids.

You know.

BILL: Then it might be hard for you to understand

The loss that a parent feels . . . .

GEORGE: They say there's nothing worse.

BILL: They're right. There isn't.

(Pause) See that hill?

My wife is on the other side of it.

GEORGE: Doing what?

BILL: Looking for my son's remains.

GEORGE: *(George rolls his eyes and whistles)*

Women. You know?

BILL: They're not the only ones who feel loss.

Men do too.

GEORGE: Not like that.

BILL: No, not like that.

That's the difference, I guess . . .

The women show it and the men don't

And they show it more because we don't

It's not fair. Really, now that I think about it.

The women have to do their own crying

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And also, the crying for the men . . .

(Pause. He reflects for a moment on this realization).

When Adam died . . .

I cut off the pain.

I had to.

I couldn't take it.

But then . . .

I didn't feel anything else either.

Just now

When I was walking these hills

And found this ticket stub from the Yankees,

I felt something.

For the first time in years.

GEORGE: You did, huh?

BILL: Yes.

(Slight pause)

Look at this thing.

(He holds up the ticket stub and looks at it with astonishment.)

It's a piece of paper

A little piece of paper.

Who would have thought

That a

Little

Piece of paper

Like this

Could have that kind of power?

(Pause)

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George . . . those clothes aren't just clothes.

They're not things.

They have life.

Just like this piece of paper.

Please.

Reconsider your decision.

Release the clothes to the women.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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